Soviets already had missile defense weapons that in some cases were more sophisticated than ours.

When it was time for me to host our annual dinner for the diplomatic corps that summer, my tablemate again was its dean, Anatoly Dobrynin. He confirmed that the Soviets wanted to meet in September in Vienna, but to talk only about space weapons. I told him we'd be in Vienna if they were, but to discuss reducing *all* kinds of nuclear weapons that operated in space, including ballistic missiles. We didn't settle anything, but I got a few things off my chest.

In late July, after stopping in Los Angeles to help open the Olympics, Nancy and I spent two weeks at the ranch, the longest uninterrupted time we'd ever spent there. She was busy planning Patti's wedding, which gave me lots of time to do some thinking on the back of my horse about our impasse with the Soviets, and I came to a decision:

Gromyko usually attended the opening session of the UN General Assembly in New York each September; after talking it over with George Shultz and Bud McFarlane, I decided to invite him to the White House after the UN meeting for a visit and some person-to-person diplomacy. As I wrote in the diary after discussing my idea with George and Bud: "I have a feeling we'll get nowhere with arms reductions while they are as suspicious of our motives as we are of theirs. I believe we need a meeting to see if we can't make them understand we have no designs on them but think they have designs on us. If we could once clear the air maybe reducing arms wouldn't look so impossible to them."

After first indicating he had no interest in my invitation, Gromyko agreed to come to the White House September 28. In the diary, I wrote: "I intend to open up the whole matter of why we don't trust them. Maybe if we can ease the mutual suspicion, arms talks can move better."

Several days before our meeting in Washington, I was scheduled to speak to the General Assembly and I went to